

Sweet taste of victory: Host Ivory Coast's journey to the title was nothing short of a movie screenplay. In the final, Franck Kessie and Sebastian Haller scored two goals in the last half-hour to complete a remarkable comeback. Pics: AP

struggling to take it all in," said coach Emerse Fae, who was brought in just ahead of the round of 16.

"When I think about all we have been through, we are miracle survivors. I can't properly express my joy. It is massive," said Fae.

Another nation that surpassed expectations was Cape Verde. The group of islands off the coast of West Africa, with a population of just 5.8 lakh, topped Group B consisting of title-favourite Egypt and Ghana.

Cape Verdean defender Roberto Lopes, who plies his trade for Shamrock Rovers in Ireland initially thought the invite to play for his dad's country, from former coach Rui Aguas on *LinkedIn* (written in Portuguese), was a spam message!

The Blue Sharks beat Mauritania in the round of 16 to qualify for the quarterfinal for only the second time but ran into third-place finisher South Africa and its keeper Ronwen Williams, who kept out four penalty kicks in the shootout.

Keeping the fun and frolic aside, the continental competition also gave rise to stories of togetherness, hope and perseverance.

DR Congo players put up a hand signal — a gun pointing to their heads with their mouths covered — ahead of its semifinal against Ivory Coast, in protest against the civilian attacks orchestrated by the M23 rebels and other Islamic groups in their country.

Mauritania, a team that skipped AFCON and World Cup qualifying tournaments in the past due to a lack of funding, managed to win its first-ever game at the tournament, even progressing to the knockouts.

The role that the Cup of Nations plays in bringing out lesser-known talent is what makes it stand apart and all eyes will be focussed on what new tales it has in store 11 months from now in Morocco.



Joyous ride: "It is more than a fairytale. I am struggling to take it all in," said Ivory Coast's coach Emerse Fae, who was brought in just ahead of the round of 16.

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